

Skills Summary

Subtracting on a Number Path

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Count Back on the Path

Rule: Put your finger on the **start** number. Hop back one box for each one you take away. The box you land on is the answer.

Example: $8 - 2$

Step 1. Taking away 2 means two hops back from the start number 8.

Step 2. Hop: 7, then 6 — two hops, landing on 6. ✓

$$\Rightarrow 8 - 2 = 6$$

Try it: $7 - 3$ (start at 7, hop back 3)

check: 4

Skill 2 — Count Up on the Path

Rule: When the number taken away is big, start at the **small** number and count the hops *up* to the start number. The number of hops is the answer.

Example: $8 - 5$

Step 1. Hopping back 5 times is a lot, so we start at 5 and count hops up to 8 instead.

Step 2. From 5, hop: 6, 7, 8 — that is 3 hops. ✓

$$\Rightarrow 8 - 5 = 3$$

Try it: $10 - 8$ (start at 8, hop up to 10)

check: 2

Skill 3 — Find the Missing Hop

Rule: If you know where a hop trip **starts** and where it **lands**, count the boxes between them — that count is the hidden number: $\text{start} - \text{hops} = \text{landing}$.

Example: $9 - \square = 5$

Step 1. We know the start 9 and the landing 5, so the missing number is the count of hops between them.

Step 2. From 9 down to 5: 8, 7, 6, 5 — that is 4 hops, and $9 - 4 = 5$. ✓

$\Rightarrow$ the missing hop number is 4

Try it: $7 - \square = 2$

check: 5

(!) Watch out: Do not count the box you start on! For $7 - 2$, your finger starts on 7 and the hops land on 6, then 5 — counting “7” as a hop lands you one too high.